

INCUBATING AN EGG

An embryo inside an egg cannot develop without warmth. Parent birds provide this by sitting on their eggs until the chicks hatch out. The process is called incubation. A mother hen such as this one will sit for 21 days.

HEN INCUBATING HER EGGS



HATCHING OUT

The pictures below show a Japanese quail hatching out of its egg. First, the emerging chick starts chipping away at the shell with its beak. Eventually, the shell cracks apart and the chick kicks itself free of the egg.



1 STARTING TO HATCH
The young chick starts chipping through the shell.

2 CRACKING OPEN
The shell cracks open and falls into two parts.

3 KICKING FREE
Using its legs and body, the chick struggles out.

4 HATCHED
The exhausted chick rests for a while after hatching.

SOME BIRD SPECIES LEAVE THEIR EGGS TO HATCH UNDER HUGE HEAPS OF VEGETATION



DUNNOCK



ANDEAN SPARROW



COMMON KINGFISHER



RICHARD'S PIPIT



CUCKOO SHRIKE



COMMON CUCKOO



GREEN WOOD-HOOPOE



HAWFINCH



JUNGLE CROW



RINGED PLOVER



JACKDAW



GUIRA CUCKOO



BARN OWL



CHIMANGO



NORTHERN LAPWING



GREY TINAMOU



OSTRICH

SOUTHERN CASSOWARY

REPTILE EGGS

Most reptiles lay eggs. Crocodiles and tortoises have hard-shelled eggs – like birds' eggs – while the eggs of turtles, snakes, and lizards are soft and leathery.



AFRICAN DWARF CROCODILE



SPUR-THIGED TORTOISE



GALAPAGOS GIANT TORTOISE



NILE MONITOR LIZARD



GRASS SNAKE



RAT SNAKE



AFRICAN HOUSE SNAKE

OTHER EGGS

Fish, insects, and slugs are among other egg-layers. Most produce very tiny eggs in large numbers. In some species, such as the dogfish, the eggs are held in a protective case.



GOLDFISH



RAINBOW TROUT



CHINESE OAK SILK MOTH CATERPILLAR



OWL BUTTERFLY CATERPILLAR



SLUG



LESSER SPOTTED DOGFISH